THE NOBULOUS SET · GAME THREE

Designed by Jonathan Weeks

Automaton of Shale (AoS)

Commit everything before you know anything. Precision pays; overkill costs.

You are the Technician running Nobulous' automaton through its paces. Each Program is a row of elements that must all be funded before a single die is rolled — and Nobulous names the dice you may *not* use first, so every allocation is made knowing exactly what you no longer have.

COMPONENTS

- 6 Experimental Technician cards
- 24 Program cards (double-sided Stable / Overheated) in three decks of 8: Routine, Specialized, Unstable
- 8 Advanced Program cards (double-sided)
- 6 Limitation cards
- 5 Element allocation mats
- **From 20 Strong:** the 17 unit dice — 4 Purple, 4 Blue, 4 Green, 4 Yellow, 1 Red
- **From 20 Strong:** the 3 stat dice — Health, Strategy and Recovery — and the Chip

SETUP

1. Choose a Technician. All six begin at **2 HP / 2 STR / 3 REC** and differ only in ability.
2. Build your Program deck — this is your difficulty. Take the stated number of Programs at random from each of the three decks, shuffle the **8** together, and return the rest to the box:

LEVEL	ROUTINE	SPECIALIZED	UNSTABLE
Easy	3	3	2
Standard	**2**	**3**	**3**
Hard	1	3	4
Nobulous	0	3	5

   Specialized stays at 3 throughout; **each step up trades one Routine Program for one Unstable**. Routine Programs ask for three elements at low Targets, Unstable ones four at high Targets, and Specialized sits between. All three decks pay the same spread of rewards, so the mix changes the workload and nothing else.
3. Shuffle the 6 Limitations into a face-down deck.
4. Shuffle the 8 Advanced Programs and set them aside for the finale.
5. Lay out the element mats.
6. All 17 dice start available.

OBJECT OF THE GAME

Cycle your 8-card Program deck three times, then face three Advanced Programs. **Surviving Advanced Programming is the win condition**: get through all three with at least 1 Health and you have won, whether or not you completed them. **If your Health reaches 0 at any point you lose.** Health can be raised by Program Rewards but never above 6 — and a Reward needs a Program finished with *no* failed elements, so the only way to heal is to do the work.

Cycling the deck

A **cycle** is one pass through every Program still in the deck: shuffle it, then run each Program once, in the order it comes up. Programs leave the deck permanently when they are **set aside** or when a Program Reward removes them, so later cycles are shorter. After the third cycle — or as soon as the deck is empty — go to Advanced Programming.

RUNNING A PROGRAM

This order matters more than anything else in the game.

1. **Reveal the Program.** It shows a row of elements, each with a Target, and one element ringed as the overheat marker.
2. **Reveal the Limitation.** It withholds dice from your available pool or imposes a constraint. Withheld dice cannot be used in this Program at all — not even for a required color.
3. **Commit required-color dice.** Every colored dot beside an element requires one available die of that color to be placed on that element *now*. These dice are locked there.
4. **Finish the allocation.** Distribute the rest of your available dice across the elements. **Every element must receive at least one die.** If you hold fewer available dice than the Program has elements, place what you have and the elements left bare fail.
5. **Execute.** Roll each element and resolve it. A hit is 1 success, a Crit is 2.

6. **Recover dice equal to your REC** at the end of every Program, before the next one is revealed.

> **REQUIRED COLORS**
>
> Red can never satisfy a required-color dot. A required die counts normally toward its element's Target — it just has to be that color, and it has to come from the dice the Limitation left you.

> **IF YOU CANNOT SUPPLY A REQUIRED COLOR**
>
> Do not execute the Program. **Lose 1 Health.** Return any withheld dice, discard the Limitation, and treat the Program as failed for Stable/Overheated progression, then move on. Running your colors dry — or letting a Shortage do it for you — has a real cost.

Routine and Unstable Programs carry one required-color dot. Specialized and Advanced carry two, with three exceptions that ask for more: *Carry a Moving Load* requires all four colors, and *Rapid Approach* and *Unobserved Entry* require three. Read the card rather than the deck. The same required colors appear on both faces of a Program card.

Limitations

Reveal exactly **1** Limitation per Program, right after the Program and *before* any required-color dice are committed. Each withholds dice from your pool, as printed. Withheld dice return when the Program ends; discard the Limitation then.

Allocation floor and cap

An element may hold at most **Target + 1** dice, unless a card raises that cap — the Engineer does, for up to 2 elements per Program — and **never fewer than one**.

The floor is there because an element you abandon is one you have decided to lose, and that decision should cost something. A failed element exhausts every die allocated to it, so the floor is exactly the price of the decision: one die, your worst, gone. Nothing else about failing changes.

ROLLING AND THE EXHAUSTION GRADIENT

Each element gets one Strategy roll. Additional rolls up to your STR form a **shared pool** spent anywhere in the Program — at STR 2 that is one extra roll for the whole Program. An extra roll is a **full reroll of that element's dice**: pick the element up, roll all of them again, and the new result *replaces* the old one, better or worse.

> **DICE COME BACK UNLESS YOU ARE PUNISHED**
>
> Allocating dice is not spending them. When an element resolves, its dice return to your available pool — **except** for the ones the table below burns.

Anything not listed below costs nothing.

RESULT	CONSEQUENCE
Exactly meet Target	**Optimal Implementation:** recover 2 exhausted dice.
Beat by 2 or more	Exhaust 1 die allocated to that element.
Fail the element	Exhaust all dice allocated to that element.
Used an extra STR roll	That element's dice exhaust regardless of outcome.

If an element uses an extra roll *and* lands exactly on Target, both apply: exhaust its dice first, then recover 2 — which may include dice you just exhausted.

> **CATASTROPHIC FAILURE**
>
> Failing exactly one element in a Program costs no Health. Failing **two or more** in the same Program is one Catastrophic Failure and costs 1 Health total. When a Catastrophic Failure occurs, you may **exhaust 2 misses on failed elements** to negate the Health loss. Count only misses still showing after any rerolls, and only on elements that actually failed.
>
> Those dice were exhausting anyway — a failed element exhausts everything allocated to it — so the negation costs you nothing beyond *having the misses there to spend*. That is the point of it: an element you have already given up on is worth loading rather than leaving bare, and the saving throw is a common out rather than a rare one.

PROGRAM REWARDS

Every Program in the Routine, Specialized and Unstable decks prints a **Program Reward**. Claim it when you complete that Program with **no failed elements at all** — one failure is enough to lose it, even though one failure costs no Health.

The reward is printed on the Program. Two of them — **+1 REC** and **+1 STR** — are permanent, and remove that Program from the deck when claimed. Advanced Programs carry no reward.

STABLE, OVERHEATED, SET ASIDE

- When a Stable Program fails, flip it to **Overheated**. The ringed element's Target increases on that face.
- If an Overheated Program fails again on a later appearance, **set it aside**.
- The endgame triggers after you have cycled the Program deck three times.

ADVANCED PROGRAMMING

- Select 3 Advanced Programs. They are longer — 4 or 5 elements — and each carries 2 required-color dots —

except Rapid Approach and Unobserved Entry, which carry three — resolved by the normal pre-allocation rule.

- Recover between Advanced Programs.
- Advanced Program 1 begins Stable.
- The next Advanced Program begins **Overheated** if this one ended in Catastrophic Failure, and **Stable** otherwise. Catastrophic Failure does not stop Advanced Programming unless Health reaches 0.

Work through all three with Health remaining to win AoS. “Work through” is the whole requirement: an Advanced Program you fail still counts as faced, and failing one costs you the game only through the Health it takes.

GIVING UP AN ELEMENT IS A DECISION, NOT A FREE MOVE

Writing off an element you cannot fund is proper play, not an exploit. One failed element costs no Health, and its dice are often worth more concentrated on the elements you *can* finish — landing one exactly on its Target pays *Optimal Implementation*. Knowing when to do it is most of the skill in AoS.
What it is not is free. Every element must hold a die, and a failed element exhausts every die on it, so each element you give up costs you one. And a Program with any failed element pays **no Program Reward**.

That last clause is what closes the door on failing your way through the game. The arithmetic looks inviting — failures retire Programs, a retired Program leaves the deck, an empty deck sends you to Advanced Programming, and Advanced Programming is won by surviving. But Health is *only* ever regained by a Program Reward. Give up an element every Program and you give up every Reward, which is the only healing there is, while still paying a die each time and still needing two failures to retire each Program. The deck outlasts you.

CARRYING AOS FORWARD

Only relevant if you are playing the Nobulous Research Journal (NRJ) campaign, which is Tier III only.

AoS contributes its **6 Backdoor Routines**, and nothing leaves the Program decks. A Routine you claimed is **retained** — at most 2, which is the claim limit a game — and the rest are **candidates**.

A retained Routine answers **Cover-Up** Exhibits in the finale, reducing a Target by **2**; it does not matter whether you went on to spend it. Claiming one costs the next Program Reward you would have taken, which is a real price — and two of those Rewards are the permanent +1 REC and +1 STR.

ROOT ACCESS IS WORTH HOLDING

Its use is to treat a failed element as successful, which saves a Catastrophic Failure. But the printed rule already lets you **exhaust 2 misses on failed elements** to negate that Health loss for nothing, so spending a Routine before trying the misses throws the card away on a problem you had already solved. Try the misses first; the Routine is there for the failure they cannot cover.